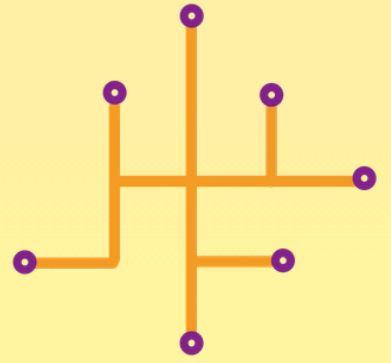




Submission to the Senate Standing Committee on Environment and Communications Inquiry into AI and Data Centres

Youth Tech Net +

ecomind



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Dear Secretary,

Youth Tech Net and EcoMind are pleased to submit the below joint comments to the Committee's Inquiry into artificial intelligence and data centres, referred by the Senate on the 13th May 2026.

Youth Tech Net

Youth Tech Net is a student-led organisation that advocates for the responsible design and governance of technology. We seek to ensure that emerging technologies are developed and deployed in ways that are responsible, equitable and responsive to the interests of young people. We support innovation that delivers meaningful public benefit, while advocating for appropriate safeguards where the design or deployment of technology creates disproportionate or long-term risks for young people and future generations.

EcoMind

EcoMind is Australia's leading youth climate mental health and wellbeing charity. The planetary crisis is having a profound impact on the mental health of young Australians, with the reality of an uncertain climate future resulting in increased rates of climate anxiety, eco-distress and burnout. We work with climate mental health researchers, practitioners and young people to develop evidence-based programs, resources and support networks to help young people care for themselves, each other and the planet. We are committed to both grassroots community capacity-building and broader systems-advocacy domestically and internationally.



Position

As young people, we perceive the presence of hyperscale data centres in Australia as a significant and unnecessary threat to both present and future environmental security and human rights, including our right to a clean, healthy and sustainable environment.

We call for a full, and immediate, moratorium on the development and construction of hyperscale data centres in Australia until the new national standards are legally enforceable and include:

1. A mandatory requirement that all hyperscale data centres run using 100% renewable energy; and
2. Mandatory reporting and regular auditing of energy consumption and water usage.

We support this action on the basis of significant concerns regarding the:

- Destruction and degradation of Australia's environment;
- Magnitude of energy and water consumption;
- Disruptions to native wildlife;
- First Nations sovereignty;
- Potential exacerbation of young Australians' already high levels of eco-anxiety and distress; and
- Ambiguous long-term economic benefit for Australia.

Additional Recommendations:

- Hyperscale data centres must use closed loop cooling and/or non-potable water;
- All hyperscale data centres must seek approval under the *Environment Protection and Biodiversity Conservation Act 1999* (Cth). Currently, there is a risk that not all data centres will need to apply for approval. We call for the new 'Water Resources' trigger to apply not only to coal and gas, but to data centre developments in recognition of their significant water usage;
- Hyperscale data centres are not permitted to use carbon credits or biodiversity certificates to 'offset' their environmental harm/emissions;



- We would prefer Australia increase investment in our renewable energy infrastructure rather than data centre development. The benefit of renewable energy to the economy, people and the environment is well-evidenced and is more consistent with human rights. Key concerns

In relation to Term of Reference #1:

1. *The effectiveness of current regulatory frameworks*

We welcome the Labour Government's new proposed standards for AI and data centres to rely on renewables and to buy back energy from the local grid so as not to drive up energy prices. We also agree with the sentiment of The National AI Plan in that digital infrastructure and skills are critical for Australia's long-term future. However, this must not come at the cost of degrading the environment or neglecting Australia's climate goals, and in fact, only presents long-term opportunity if it is developed sustainably. Youth do not support the developments of the August 2026 Cabinet meeting concerning carve-outs for non-renewable energy in to power data centres and urge the government to maintain a strong stance on using 100% renewables.



2. The role of big tech and AI in young people's lives

As young people, we are concerned with the concentration of political and economic power into the hands of foreign tech companies. Young people are seeing an increase in political radicalisation, and mental health conditions caused by the development and design of big tech products. For example, landmark cases such as *New Mexico v. Meta Platforms inc.*, and *Garcia v Character Technologies*, in the US, have recently shown that big tech social media platforms and AI chatbot providers are deliberately designed to manipulate and exploit young people, constitute a public nuisance, and do so in the interest of securing market competitiveness. Considering this, if the projected increase in the number of data centres in Australia correlates to further large-scale AI use, we are concerned that the influence of foreign tech companies would be exacerbated by a widespread push for AI. Rather than directly benefiting young Australians, this would risk further subjecting us and future youth to exploitation by American tech companies.

While the projected benefit to Australia and our economy from AI shows promise in industries such as medicine, scientific research and development, and advanced computing, encouraging data centre investment in Australia without consideration of the role of big tech companies such as Meta Platforms, inc., OpenAI, and Anthropic, risks further consolidating the harms that they perpetrate against young people. We suggest that any proposed development of AI infrastructure must first demonstrate how it would provide direct benefit to Australia and our people (especially the communities in close proximity to the data centre).



In relation to Term of Reference #2:

1. Longitudinal impacts on future generations:

As young people, we are concerned specifically with the long-term effects of new infrastructure. While we recognise that the future will be increasingly digitised, we urge the Government to consider that the long-term sustainability of our digital infrastructure relies on that of our environment. Of particular concern is where and how data centres source energy from. If our infrastructure is to be of longitudinal benefit to Australians, the energy used to facilitate digital transformation must be sustainable.

2. Impact on the environment:

As affirmed by the International Court of Justice in 2025, all States have a legal duty to prevent significant environmental harm and uphold the human rights of present and future generations. Australia therefore has an obligation not to pursue or permit any action or development which is known to have deleterious environmental impacts. In regards to hyperscale data centres, we are particularly concerned about the:

- **Risk to biodiversity:** Australia is home to 10% of the world's biodiversity, and yet we have the second highest rate of biodiversity loss and highest rate of mammalian extinction globally. The construction of hyperscale data



- centres further threatens these ecosystems (e.g., through land clearing, draining local water sources and light/noise pollution disrupting native wildlife).
- **Increasing risk of drought and water scarcity:** The United Nations has warned that we are entering an era of global water bankruptcy. In a drought-prone country which frequently faces severe regional water scarcity, we want our fresh water to be conserved for human and agricultural use, not consumed by data centres.
- **Disruption to native wildlife:** Hyperscale data centres are associated with 24/7 light and sound pollution and habitat fragmentation. This can significantly disrupt wildlife behaviour, migration, hunting and mating (particularly for nocturnal species).

3. Hyperscale data centres are incompatible with Australia's domestic and international commitments

- The resource-intensiveness of hyperscale data centres is highly likely to undermine Australia's fulfilment of its Nationally Determined Contribution under the Paris Agreement. In 2025, Australia submitted its updated Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC). Our current 2035 emissions reduction target (62–70% reduction in greenhouse gas emissions from 2005 levels) is aligned with neither the best available science nor industry



recommendations, and is consistent with global warming of 2.4oC. According to four independent analyses undertaken by industry leaders, Australia would need to reduce emissions by 75–77% for the 2035 target to accurately account for its emissions, and align with our obligations under the Paris Agreement. Other research and scientific institutions have also released reports strongly suggesting that the best available science actually indicates a need to achieve net zero by 2035.

We do not support plans to establish Australia as the ‘AI capital of the Pacific’ when we are already not on track to fulfil our international climate obligations. Australia is the 14th highest emitter globally, without accounting for the additional emissions which will be generated by hyperscale data centres. We are strictly opposed to any action which will increase national emissions and undermine our pathway to net zero.

1. Impact on young people and the communities which sustain them:

We are concerned about the impact that AI and hyperscale data centres will have on climate change, inequality, job security, democracy and privacy.

Many of us associate generative-AI and data centres with:

- A loss of control and sense of powerlessness at not being able to ‘opt out’;
- Increased misinformation and political radicalisation;



- Threats to privacy and data sovereignty;
- Erosion of educational and academic integrity;
- Weakened social connection;
- Devaluation of human skills, including creativity and effort; and
- Increased social and economic disparity (i.e., wealth and power concentrated in a handful of tech giants)

Specifically:

- Young people are worried about the power, water and emissions burden of hyperscale data centres, which is exacerbating already high rates of eco-distress: On average, 76% of young people in Australia report that climate change and environmental degradation negatively impact their wellbeing, with 25% reporting that this eco-distress interferes with their daily functioning. Growing concern about AI use and hyperscale data centres (65% of Australians believe AI “creates more problems than it solves”) is likely to exacerbate existing eco-anxiety, hopelessness, and institutional distrust.
- The environmental impact of data centres will disproportionately affect lower socio-economic communities and regional/rural areas, compounding existing social and economic inequality: Many proposed data centres are seeking approval to be developed in regional and remote areas, particularly the Northern Territory. These are areas which are already disproportionately vulnerable to climate disasters (e.g., heatwaves, bushfires, flooding, cyclones etc.) and which face ongoing challenges in accessing adequate resources and infrastructure.
- Fear of job insecurity: Young people are growing up in an increasingly volatile, uncertain world, and the proliferation of generative-AI is adding to this sense of insecurity. Work provides not only economic security, but also a sense of identity, purpose and social connection. Young people are anxious and fearful about both job insecurity and identity disruption in the face of AI (noting that the International Monetary Fund estimates that 40% of jobs will be impacted by AI).



We request that the Committee please carefully and thoroughly consider the above concerns and recommendations.

Sincerely,

Youth Tech Net and EcoMind